

4.1.1 Aspects of tragedy

At the core of all the set texts is a tragic hero or heroine who is flawed in some way, who suffers and causes suffering to others and in all texts there is an interplay between what might be seen as villains and victims. Some tragic features will be more in evidence in some texts than in others and students will need to understand how particular aspects of the tragic genre are used and how they work in the three chosen texts. The absence of an 'aspect' can be as significant as its presence.

There can be no exhaustive list of the 'aspects' of tragedy but areas that can usefully be explored include:

- the type of the tragic text itself, whether it is classical and about public figures, like Lear, or domestic and about representations of ordinary people, like Tess
- the settings for the tragedy, both places and times
- the journey towards death of the protagonists, their flaws, pride and folly, their blindness and insight, their discovery and learning, their being a mix of good and evil
- the role of the tragic villain or opponent, who directly affects the fortune of the hero, who engages in a contest of power and is partly responsible for the hero's demise
- the presence of fate, how the hero's end is inevitable
- how the behaviour of the hero affects the world around him, creating chaos and affecting the lives of others
- the significance of violence and revenge, humour and moments of happiness
- the structural pattern of the text as it moves through complication to catastrophe, from order to disorder, through climax to resolution, from the prosperity and happiness of the hero to the tragic end
- the use of plots and sub-plots
- the way that language is used to heighten the tragedy
- ultimately how the tragedy affects the audience, acting as a commentary on the real world, moving the audience through pity and fear to an understanding of the human condition.

Students study **one** of the following Shakespeare plays:

Author	Text
William Shakespeare	<i>Othello</i>
	<i>King Lear</i>

Students study **two** texts including **one** drama from the following list. At least **one** of the texts must be written pre-1900.

Author	Text	Time period
F. Scott Fitzgerald	<i>The Great Gatsby</i>	
Thomas Hardy	<i>Tess of the D'Urbervilles</i>	Pre-1900
John Keats	'Lamia', 'Isabella or The Pot of Basil', 'La Belle Dame Sans Merci', 'The Eve of St. Agnes'	Pre-1900
Arthur Miller	<i>Death of a Salesman</i> (drama)	
William Shakespeare	<i>Richard II</i> (drama)	Pre-1900
AQA English Literature B Poetry anthology (tragedy)	Extracts from the Prologue of 'The Monk's Tale' and <i>The Monk's Tale</i> , 'Jessie Cameron', Extract from <i>Paradise Lost</i> , 'Tithonus', 'The Convergence of the Twain', 'The Death of Cuchulain', 'Out, out...', 'Death in Leamington', 'Miss Gee'	

We do not expect to change texts within the first five years of the specification. However, texts will be reviewed each year starting in September 2017 and we will give at least nine months' notice of any changes prior to first teaching of a two year course. The criteria for changing texts will be where a text becomes unavailable or where we can no longer use it in a question paper. Notice of any change will be communicated via our exam bulletins and aqa.org.uk/english